

ABUNDANCE VERSUS ACCEPTANCE

Greetings my dearest, dearest friends. Blessings for every one of you. Blessed be this new year you start. May it be crowned with success in your endeavors for spiritual growth.

Man is often confused by apparent contradictions regarding spiritual truth. We have often discussed such facets, and I always point out the common denominator which brings two apparent contradictions into a unity. This is of great importance. It eliminates confusion. It eliminates an either/or situation.

Tonight's topic is a very fundamental one in man's approach to life. Every one of you can find substantial help in this lecture if you truly listen, if you think deeply about these words, and if you study this lecture. It will answer questions within yourself whether or not you were aware of the existence of these unanswered questions.

There are two philosophies about life and spiritual reality which seem completely contradictory. The one says that the spiritually and emotionally mature person has to learn to accept the difficulties in life. It says that in order to cope with life he has to accept what he cannot immediately change, what is beyond his direct sphere of influence. It says that lack of acceptance breeds disharmony, anxiety, tension, and increases the difficulties. It destroys peace of mind. The ability to accept the inevitable -- such as death or other acts of destiny -- is a gauge to maturity and to a well-rounded personality.

The other philosophy says that nothing negative need be accepted, that all hardship, even death, is unnecessary. It says that there is no destiny other than the one man molds for himself, that man, whenever he decides to, can mold a new destiny in which he no longer suffers. It postulates that true spiritual awakening is marked by the realization that suffering does not need to be accepted, that the universe is open in immeasurable abundance available for all human beings -- right here and right now.

These are apparent contradictions. Not seeing that there is no contradiction in these two approaches must create confusion whether or not you are aware of it. You have undoubtedly found both these attitudes and approaches in all great spiritual teachings as well as in my own lectures. In practically everything I have taught you, both these approaches are present.

Now, my friends, why are these two approaches not mutually exclusive? Where do they combine? Where is the common denominator, the key that unifies? The answer lies in the element of fear. If you wish happiness because you fear unhappiness, happiness remains unreachable. If you wish happiness for the sake of being happy and not because you fear its absence, no block toward its attainment exists. And this is an enormous difference.

As long as you fear, it is sometimes -- although not always -- inevitable to go through that which is feared in order to lose the fear. If fear can be shed by realization of the truth that there is no reason to fear, then it is not necessary to go through it. But man is often incapable of doing so, hence he must familiarize himself so much with the feared circumstances that they lose their threat.

As long as you wish the positive because you fear the negative, this fear barricades the way to the positive. This sphere of consciousness, the planet earth, with its individuals in their overall state of development is distinguished by the fact that most personalities desire the positive because they fear its opposite negative. Let us examine a few of man's fundamental desires.

Let us begin with the great duality of life and death. This will give us more understanding of the lecture that I gave on this topic a few years ago. I said then that life and death are the same, two facets of one and the same process. I said that man must learn the ability of dying, that he will do so by acceptance, and by acceptance he will learn that there is nothing to be feared -- in fact, that there is no death. I also said that he who fears life must fear death, and vice versa.

It is impossible to truly love life as long as one fears death. This can be constantly corroborated when observing human reactions a bit closer. The more a person lives with gusto and joy, the less does he fear death. The more he shrinks in fear from death, the more he clings to life, but wishing life in order to avoid death, not because he enjoys it or because he is dynamically related to living. This shows that he really does not live at all. His fear of death and dying prohibits him from living. And only by deeply living can it be learned that life is one unending process, and dying is a temporary illusion. If man clings to life because he fears death, his life will not be meaningful, nor can it be pleasurable. Needless to say, this is, as always, a question to a degree. Since hardly anyone is completely free of the fear of death -- otherwise they would not be incarnated in this sphere of being -- there is hardly anyone who truly lives. But there are some who are relatively free from this fear and who therefore live relatively meaningful and pleasurable lives.

Since it is almost impossible for the average soul to realize that death is not to be feared, it has to go through cycles and cycles of embodiments -- one after the other -- thereby learning to die until death, or dying, is no longer a frightening experience for the soul. When the fear of dying is overcome, life eternal is possible. As long as dying is feared, dying must be gone through.

Another great aim of man is the wish to be in control. Conversely, he fears its absence. As spiritual truth teachings postulate that death is unnecessary, so do they claim that man is master of the universe once he is truly evolved, that he and he alone controls his destiny. Man's soul strives toward this goal. But as long as he does so because he fears lack of control, he must learn the ability to let go of it, to relinquish it, to flexibly adjust, adjust to what is, if need be. He must learn the fine balance between taking the reins into his own hands, conducting his ship through the river of life, and the ability to let go. The more man fears to let go, the greater the imbalance of his soul movements, and the more he must lose the final control over his destiny. The tight control he grabs at is a pseudocontrol that does not achieve anything. It merely makes him tense and anxious. It prohibits peace and confidence in himself and in the life process. The only way this confidence can grow is by entrusting himself into what seems the "unknown," by giving up the tense hold. Thereby he eventually gains full mastery, without fear of losing it, for he now knows that there is nothing to fear.

Where man stands now, he is not yet capable of immediate control over himself and his life in all respects. He still has to accept, temporarily, certain limitations within himself which create an undesirable destiny. To force these results away by sheer outer will, and due to fear, must make the situation worse. Temporary acceptance of one's present limitations and, consequently of the momentary results does not mean resignation to tragedy and suffering. It merely means going through a passing phase of lesser expansion, comfort, and bliss, accepting one's limitations and responsibility for this present state, thereby overcoming the dread of it. Hence, the door will open.

The truth that man, in his highest evolutionary state, is in control of his destiny includes his ability to let go and entrust himself to greater forces than himself. In fact, only by doing so can he become one with these forces. When man refuses to let go, to relinquish control, he naturally does so out of fear and distrust. Thus he blocks against that which is most benign, which is his power, his liberation, his bliss.

A further fundamental human aim is pleasure supreme. All these facets under discussion -- eternal life, control over one's destiny, pleasure supreme -- are deeply inborn, spiritually instinctive aims. The psyche knows that this is its destiny and this is its origin. It strives to recapture it.

If man desires pleasure because he fears pain or fears the absence of pleasure, the door to pleasure remains closed. Once he has learned that the absence of pleasure is not the abyss of darkness he has shrunk from, fear will no longer prohibit him from fulfillment.

Every facet of living applies to this principle. If man desires health in a spirit of fearing sickness, he barricades health. If man fears the aging process, he barricades eternal youth. If man fears poverty, he barricades abundance. If man fears loneliness, he barricades real companionship. If man fears companionship, he barricades his self-containment. So it goes on and on all across the board.

The great enemy is fear. The best way to meet and conquer this enemy is first to ascertain, admit, and pronounce it. This will diminish it to a considerable degree and open the way to further measures of ousting it. Of course, this desire must, as always, be clearly expressed in one's thinking and intentions. However, if fear is worked against due to fear of fear, it will be difficult. Therefore the calm admission of it, the momentary acceptance of it will do more toward eliminating it than fighting against it.

A long time ago, we discussed that the three major stumbling blocks in man's soul are pride, self-will, and fear. The more man unifies, the more does he always reach one basic point. The same applies to this triad. Pride and self-will are easily overcome when there is no more fear. If you do not fear to have your dignity impaired, there will be no need for false pride. And if you do not fear to be controlled by elements you have no influence over, you will have no need for self-will.

Fear is the great locked door which prohibits man from entering -- right here and right now -- into all that which is immediately available the moment fear is uprooted from his heart and soul.

This is what this life is all about, my friends. This is what this human sphere of consciousness, with its repeated incarnations in which you go through schools of experience, is all about. And this is what our path here is all about: the discovery that fear is unnecessary.

When man hears the admonition that it is necessary to learn acceptance, this always seems to imply that he has to accept an ultimate fate of suffering and deprivation. When he is admonished to learn letting go of his control, this implies that he releases himself into an abyss of danger, pain, hardship. This is why his fear increases, and so does his tense reluctance and stubbornness. He more rigidly shrinks and cringes from that which is his liberation, his life eternal, his bliss. In truth, acceptance must bring him to the realization that he is called upon to accept that which is most desirable for him. Giving up control, the little self-will, finally proves to man that this releases him into a new freedom, into something positive and desirable rather than negative and undesirable. So there is no longer any need to fearfully hold on to control.

When the soul is sufficiently experienced and deeply impressed with the truth -- namely that there is nothing to fear -- the human personality suddenly comes to a point of realization and discovery in which acceptance is no longer a risk, for it embraces and includes the entire benign universe. Then there is no longer the question of going through the fear in order to rise above it. Then he is ready and prepared for all the fulfillment, all the abundance, the bliss and pleasure supreme in liberated life, and the life eternal with all its dynamic, joyful aspects. All that man's heart desires is immediately open when he has overcome fear. Nothing stands in the way when fear of the opposite has gone.

When you realize this truth, it is the liberation your spirit has been waiting for. It is coming into your own. It is as though your spirit says, "Oh, that is the way it is. Why did I not see this wonderful simplicity before? Why did I plague myself with all this unnecessary hardship?" And you step out from your confinement. The world becomes your own!

But where the soul is not yet ready for this realization, it has to learn that there is nothing to fear. It does so through being involved in a world that expresses this ignorance -- for only thus can the ignorance (that there is nothing to fear) be broken through. The truth must be discovered by the self that even that which hurts and deprives at the moment is never quite that which one fears.

You all have had this experience, my friends. When you fearfully anticipate a certain event, how many times did you find out that, after having gone through it, it was not half as bad as you had feared?

This leads us to the important fact that the main element of fear is not a particular undesirable factor or event, but an unknown quality about it. The most important element about fear is the unknown quality about it. Now, it is possible to fear something one already has experienced -- either consciously or unconsciously. But, when going through an experience while in a state of fear, all faculties and perceptions become dulled. The truth of the experience is not fully registered, assimilated, perceived. The fear blurs one's view and one's capacity to evaluate in objectivity. So, it is very possible to have gone through an experience in a certain frame of mind and come out with the impression that this experience was not as it really was but as one had expected it to be.

That is why the soul often requires so many repetitions until it can rid itself of fear. This applies particularly to the experience of dying. Let me assure you, my friends, that the trauma of being born is an infinitely greater one than the one of dying. Yet, a peculiar mass image exists about the frightening element of dying. This mass image is deeply impressed on all those souls who come, again and again, to this earth sphere. When an individual goes through the, in itself, liberating event of shedding the material body, this mass image produces such a fear that he is too tense and anxious to register the event of dying in full consciousness.

In addition is the fact that his conscious intellect ignores the factors of dying but meets an unknown element about it. His fear half-anesthetizes him. Hence the truth cannot impress itself upon him. What he has experienced is hazy due to a very low consciousness at this moment. And the little that has registered is of course easily forgotten, for memory is also dependent on a free state of mind, uncluttered by fear, prejudice, and misconceptions. The little the soul does remember is soon blotted out by the strength of the mass image that again takes effect on the individual.

So, frequently it happens that an individual registers, at the time of the transition, "Oh, is this what it is? That is wonderful." But as explained above, the mass image cannot be blotted out when the truth cannot be experienced in full consciousness. And fear barricades such a full experience. But with each repetition, a little more of the truth penetrates until slowly but surely the soul rids itself of this fear and becomes quite relaxed regarding the transition -- as relaxed as you are about going to sleep at night or as relaxed as you are when you start a new phase of your life about which you have no unknown, fear-producing qualms, but rather look forward to. Dying is produced by the fear of it. It becomes superfluous and ceases to take place when the fear of it vanishes.

The same principle applies to many other facets of living -- those I have used as examples and many others I did not mention. Wherever fear exists, this fear produces the circumstances one fears. These circumstances are, at the same time, the only way to convince the self that the fear is unnecessary.

The more known an event is, the less is it feared. A vicious circle exists in that fear prohibits the faculties to get to know. It dulls the senses. But every vicious circle can be broken. You may argue that actual pain can be very much feared. But, my friends, think about it. Pain is inordinately feared only when one does not know where it will lead, when one suspects something dangerous in it, a serious disease and finally death. If it is known that a pain will not bring any threat to one's safety, it can be borne in a relaxed state of mind and thus cease to be pain.

When you meet your fears and squarely acknowledge them, it is important to understand and specifically ascertain the unknown element about it. Then you have a chance of making the unknown element a little less unknown until perhaps completely eliminating the unknown character of it in certain instances, while, in others, consciously accepting the fact that some element must remain unknown for the time being and simultaneously accepting the fear.

Where there is an uncertainty what the future will bring, there is fear. Nothing one truly knows, even the greatest difficulties, are really feared. In order to make the unknown known, the feared unknown must often be entered into -- just like the experience of dying. But this must, by no means, be construed to mean the looking for negative, painful experience.

When you open your whole psyche for positive experience without a trace of fear of the negative, then the unknown must become more and more known; life becomes more and more of a fulfillment on all levels.

Now, my friends, are there any questions regarding this?

QUESTION: Is this the only sphere in which one goes through this experience of death as we know it?

ANSWER: This is so. In other spheres, there are other experiences equally important for the evolution of the soul.

QUESTION: Are only those who fear death incarnated in this sphere?

ANSWER: That is one reason of drawing these souls into this particular sphere of consciousness. But a lot of other facts are connected with it. If a person is afraid of dying, that fundamental fear leads to a lot of other soul conditions and is connected with a great number of other erroneous concepts. They are all interconnected. As I have said before, afraid of dying is also afraid of living -- of the unknown elements of both. When such fears exist, there must be misconceptions, erroneous imprints in the soul.

When fear constricts the soul, man is incapable of entering into and becoming a part of the cosmic life force which gently guides him to fruition and which wants to envelop him. He stems against it as though it were his enemy. In reality, the enemy sits within himself, a product of false fears, misconception, unnecessary limitations. It is due to them that man turns against himself, and in spite of a part of his spirit continuously striving for his birthright of fulfillment, another part of himself actually strives for nonfulfillment, pain, deprivation. The great danger that he falsely believes is unavoidable seems less threatening when he quickly brings it about himself. At least, it is then no longer unknown. But avoidable negative experience has a bitter taste. Negative experience courted out of fear and error is much harder to bear than negative experience that is a result of still lingering limitations one does not rush into, voluntarily, as it were. And this is so very often the case with man. It requires deep insight into the mechanics of one's inner life processes to even discover this. Only then is it possible to stop this destructive process.

When man learns the rhythm of his life, when he no longer stems against, rushes into, forces ahead, thereby disturbing the natural rhythm, he will become part of the great cosmic powers with which he can play and build, and thus he becomes truly master of the universe.

QUESTION: What do you mean by spheres?

ANSWER: Spheres of consciousness, spheres of being. Where entities with a more or less similar state of consciousness flock together -- and they do so according to immutable law -- that overall consciousness can be referred to as a sphere. From a point of view of space, the geographical area may be indicated as such. From a spiritual viewpoint, time, space, and movement are all expressions of particular states of consciousness. This is why it is difficult for an entity geared in three-dimensional thinking to comprehend utterings of a consciousness that comprises not only

more dimensions, but unifies these dimensions into plain consciousness -- its state, caliber, and degree.

Hence, when spiritual spheres are discussed, the danger exists that man begins to think of them in oversimplified terms of geographical areas located somewhere in outer space. Although it cannot be regarded as untrue that the entire universe is inhabited, all space, all time, all planets, all stellar systems, the real universe with all its myriads of spheres, is within man. However, this does not make the existence of many more spiritual worlds abstract ideas. They are reality, just as each planet is a reality and exists within and without.

Now when I speak of entities with more or less compatible overall development, this must not be taken literally. There is a margin. It cannot be denied that there is considerable difference in development among human beings -- and so of course among entities of other spheres of consciousness. Yet they all have certain points in common in spite of great differences in perception and comprehension of older, more developed spirits, and younger ones, relatively new in this state or phase. But there is a definite limit in both directions. They all can fulfill themselves just by flocking together and by the various differences that arise from them. This is why they are drawn together and make up a so-called sphere.

QUESTION: I can't visualize a sphere. Could you give an example of another sphere?

ANSWER: In a different lecture, I explained that conditions on this earth sphere are an exact expression of the sum total of the consciousness of all human beings inhabiting this sphere. This also comprises, of course, those individuals who do not at this moment reside in a body but congenitally belong to this sphere by their overall development and who will therefore reincarnate again here. I explained that all the beauty on this earth, in nature and that which is created by man, is a direct expression of those inner qualities which are in harmony with the universe. Conversely, all strife such as war, poverty, quarreling, difficulties of all sorts, sickness and dying, are the expression of man's confusions, his state of consciousness in which he clings to destructive emotions. In other words, this earth with all its conditions, favorable and unfavorable, the greatness and the pettiness, are all a direct result of all the consciousnesses which inhabit it. All that can be called a "sphere of consciousness." Other spheres express the consciousness, the sum total of all consciousness, too. If the overall consciousness is higher than this one, conditions are accordingly more harmonious and less difficult. Where the general level of perception of truth is higher, it is inevitable that less limiting circumstances arise in such a sphere.

QUESTION: Do we reincarnate into the same sphere?

ANSWER: Until man has learned to overcome whatever the present state of consciousness expresses in disharmony and error. From all I have said -- in the past as well as in this lecture -- it is obvious that as long as consciousness is not raised to a higher degree of perception of truth, a new sphere cannot be created for this particular entity. For his environment and his inner state of consciousness are one and the same.

Man is not reincarnated into the same sphere because any deity "sends" or "commands" him to do so, but this is a process of attraction and repulsion according to law. It is like the laws of chemical formulas. You must not imagine that first exists the sphere, and then man is put into it or

incarnated into it. It is the other way around. The sphere is a result of man's thinking, feelings, his attitudes, his general state -- the sum total of his entire personality. The sphere expresses him. If he expresses other qualities than this sphere, he is no longer drawn to it, but to such a sphere as is the expression of the majority of beings, including himself.

QUESTION: Are other spheres physical, as ours?

ANSWER: Man makes too arbitrary a distinction between physical and nonphysical. He consists of many layers, each is matter of a special density. The higher the consciousness, the finer the consistency of the matter. But this does not make him formless or his existence less real.

According to his beliefs, he will be drawn into spheres of more physical -- i.e., denser matter -- or finer vibrations. If his entire thinking is still geared on a very superficial and materialistic plane, the matter he produces for the vehicle of his spirit will be accordingly. The denser the matter, the more ignorance, error, misconceptions, prejudice, limitation, darkness; hence the more suffering.

When man realizes that his real self is not just in the body, his perceptions will widen, and the matter of his entire soul substance will become much finer, more sensitive to truth. A greater sense of reality will be the result.

It is extremely important for all of you who work on this path to find, particularly as it applies to you, where you fear the negative and therefore grab for the positive alternative. When you find these areas of fear and wanting the positive for negative motivations, it will be much easier for you to rid yourself of this condition. You will then be able to go into the rich abundance of life with a lifted head, as a free person. It is this soul movement that makes all the difference.

It is this soul condition of fearlessness of the negative that produces the conviction that nothing negative is ever necessary and that man's fate is bliss, unfoldment, dynamic life. And where the conviction exists, outer facts must follow suit. Shrinking away from a feared alternative and, because of that, wishing the positive, desirable alternative makes the latter an unreachable illusion. This may explain to many of my friends why a number of doors have remained closed in spite of much progress and insights. However, it does require just such an extended awareness, through the insights gained, to even notice the existence of such a fear, to be aware of the fine differentiation between wanting happiness for the sake of happiness or wanting it in order to avoid unhappiness.

I have discussed major, general aims. There are many specific desires with their fear of their opposites which have to be ascertained in your personal work. There is nothing big or little, important or unimportant when it comes to the human psyche. For anything that may offhand appear like an insignificant aspect, is, in the last analysis, connected with the great questions of life. When you find these elements, this will open new doors for you, my friends. Even before you can shed the fear itself; ascertaining it, knowing what it means must make a great difference in your attitude to yourself, to life, and to the particular desire that had remained unfulfilled, due to the hitherto overlooked shift in motivation. This is an all-important key.

It must not be overlooked either that the presence of fear of the negative does not necessarily eliminate also a healthy wish for the positive, for the sake of the positive. It is absolutely possible, in

fact it is frequent that a healthy wish exists, but it is simultaneously accompanied by the distorted motivation -- the fear of the undesirable alternative.

Once you can put your finger on the fear, you can directly treat it in your meditations. This will make a great deal of difference on your path. It can be a real solution to many problems for many of you that have been stubbornly locked so far. The mere realization, "I cannot step out into freedom because I want freedom due to fear of imprisonment," will bring liberation a great step nearer. If you realize that you cannot be free because you fear unfreedom, in that realization greater freedom is yours. This may sound very complicated and quite paradoxical. But if you deeply think about it, you will understand how true it is. You will know this truth!

Blessings for every one of you, my friends. May these words lift your spirit and bring you nearer to the light of truth, to the reality of love, to the unending bliss of spiritual existence. Be in peace, be in God!

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